

On aspiration and length in diachrony

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Within a recent debate on the reconstruction of Proto-Indo-European stop contrasts, Kloekhorst (2026: 164f.), arguing against a “voice[lessness]-to-length” change (as assumed by Kümmel 2007: 176; 2019), has claimed that the attested geminate stops of Upper German dialects as continuants of Old High German (OHG) singleton fortis stops (e.g. Swiss German *bätte* [pæt:ə] ‘to pray’ < OHG *betōn*), are not relevant to the debate since they might show a change from aspiration (not voice) to gemination. This is clearly based on a false premise, namely that the current Standard German realization of fortis stops as aspirates comes from (an older stage of) Upper German, while it actually reflects the Low German pronunciation of written High German, and actual Upper German varieties do not show an evidence for aspiration of such fortis stops.

However, aside from this empirical problem the proposal raises the more general question whether a change from aspirated stops to geminates would be more plausible than one from simple voiceless stops to (unaspirated) geminates. Evidence for such a type of change seems very slim: Kloekhorst himself does not give any further example, and Kümmel (2007) does not list any such case. The opposite change from long stops to aspirates appears to be rare, too, but here, Kümmel (2007: 169) gives at least some possible examples in Greek and Inari Saami. It may also be relevant that (allophonic or phonological) aspiration of fortis stops seems to be restricted to singletons in some languages while geminates are unaspirated, e.g. Ossetic, Lezgian, Swedish, or Ancient Greek; but also the opposite appears to be possible, e.g., in Cypriot Greek where geminate (long) stops are aspirated but singletons are not (Arvaniti 1999: 174). The aim of my talk is to investigate the diachronic and synchronic relation of stop aspiration and length more closely. Can we make any generalizations about the probability of changes in one or the other directions?

References

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